

S-Town Worksheet

Exercise 1

- a) What role does the introduction about the challenges of fixing old clocks play in this episode?
- b) What is the main focus of this episode?
- c) What/who is the donkey in this episode? What information does it carry?
- d) How does the podcast engage the reader?
- e) Characterise John B. McLemore. Use quotes from the episode.
- f) Describe the setting. How does John describe the area in which he lives?
- g) What narrative devices to create suspense are used in this episode?
 - Foreshadowing
 - Surprises
 - Hooks
 - Cliffhangers
- h) John has given Brian Reed three short stories to read: "A Rose for Emily", "The Necklace", and "The Renegade". What role do the short stories play in the podcast? How does Reed use them?
- i) Listen to different quotes from John. How would you characterise the way he speaks?
- j) Look up the words *offglide* and *monophthong*. Can you find examples of these characteristics of Alabama English in the podcast?

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Student post-it notes

1. Old clocks
Fixing clocks = metaphor. Small hidden problems matter, and you need patience to understand S-Town and John.

2. Main focus
Brian investigates John's claims about a murder, but it also becomes a portrait of John and Woodstock.

3. Donkey
The donkey is the rumour/story John sends Brian after. It carries information about the alleged murder.

4. Engagement
Mystery, strange details, John's voice, and Brian's questions make us want to keep listening.

5. John
Brilliant, angry, funny, lonely. He cares about truth and detail, but sounds very frustrated with his town.

6. Setting
Rural Alabama. John calls it corrupt and backwards. The place feels hot, poor, isolated, and full of gossip.

7. Suspense
Foreshadowing, cliffhangers, unanswered questions, and sudden twists. The episode keeps changing direction.

8. Short stories
They work like clues. Reed uses them to show how John thinks about secrets, death, irony, and hidden lives.

9. John's speech
Fast, detailed, sarcastic, poetic, and full of strong opinions. He sounds educated and Southern at the same time.

10. Alabama English
Offglide = vowel moves at the end. Monophthong = vowel stays flat. Listen for Southern pronunciation in John's words like *time*.